am only saying that the laws of physics determine a correlation between ourselves and the temperature (for instance, I've looked at a thermometer), but not between ourselves and the velocity of the individual molecules. It is the same notion of information as the one I started from in this chapter: the white ball in your hand 'has information' about the fact that the ball in my hand is black. We're dealing with physical facts, not mental notions. A ball has information, in this sense, even if the ball does not have mental states, just as a USB storage device contains information (the number of gigabytes printed on the device tells us how much information it can contain), even if a USB storage device does not think. Information in this sense – correlation between states of systems – is ubiquitous throughout the universe.

I believe that in order to understand reality we have to keep in mind that reality is this network of relations, of reciprocal information, which weaves the world. We slice up the reality surrounding us into objects. But reality is not made up of discrete objects. It is a variable flux. Think of an ocean wave. Where does a wave finish? Where does it begin? Think of mountains. Where does a mountain start? Where does it end? How far does it continue beneath the Earth's surface? These are questions without much sense, because a wave and a mountain are not objects in themselves; they are ways which *we* have of slicing up the world to apprehend it, to speak about it more easily. These limits are arbitrary, conventional, comfortable: they depend on us (as physical systems) more than on the waves or the mountains. They are ways of organizing the information which we have or, better, forms of information which we have.

It's the same for every object, properly considered, including living organisms. This is why it makes little sense to ask whether a half-cut fingernail is still 'me' or has become 'not-me'; or if the hairs left on my sofa by the cat are still part of the cat, or not; or precisely when a child's life begins. A child begins to live on the day when a person dreams of her for the first time, long before her conception, or when she forms her first self-image, or when she breathes for the first time, or when she recognizes her name, or when we apply any number of other conventions: they are all useful, but arbitrary. They are ways to think, and to orientate ourselves within the complexity of reality.

A living organism is a system which continually re-forms itself in order to remain itself, interacting ceaselessly with the external world. Of such organisms, only those continue to exist which are more efficient at doing so and, therefore, living organisms manifest properties which have suited them for survival. For this reason, they are interpretable, and we interpret them, in terms of intentionality, of purpose. The finalistic aspects of the biological world (this is Darwin's momentous discovery) are therefore the result of the selection of complex forms effective in persisting. But the effective way of